Quattrocchi (a reference to the Italian businessman and Bofors accused who was close to the Gandhi family)!'

Keen not to lose a key ally, the Congress buckled. With Sonia Gandhi giving the go-ahead, the prime minister gave up. On 28 May, three Cabinet ministers of the DMK were sworn in. The list included Mr Raja who was given the prized telecom ministry once again, the very portfolio that the prime minister didn't want to give him. Dr Singh had conceded the fight. He would pay a heavy price for the concession.

Eighteen months later, Raja was forced to resign after a report of the CAG accused him of not distributing 2G spectrum in a transparent manner, resulting in an alleged loss of Rs 1.76 lakh crore to the exchequer. A few months later, he was arrested. Raja was a feisty character. A lawyer-politician from the Nilgiris, he exuded a certain political machismo. Days before he was arrested, I had a hearty south Indian breakfast with him, trying to convince him to do an interview. He sounded defiant, even as he munched on his dosa. 'If they arrest me, I will expose everyone. The prime minister, the finance minister—they all knew what was happening, why am I being singled out?' he asked angrily.

Till then, Manmohan Singh's calling card had been his spotless track record of personal probity. In his long career in public life, there had never been an accusation that the prime minister had engaged in, or winked at, corruption. The 2G case noticeably changed that. A series of letters emerged in the public domain suggesting that the prime minister was aware in 2008 itself that Raja was subverting the spectrum allocation process, possibly for personal benefit, but that Dr Singh had asked, in the words of one such communication, 'to be kept at arm's-length'.

PMO sources claimed that this was the reason why the prime minister had not wanted Raja in his Cabinet again. The fact, though, is that Raja continued as telecom minister for almost two years after the controversial 2G spectrum allocation. Dr Singh could have acted against him but chose the path of least resistance. He had failed to exercise prime ministerial authority and had revealed a weakness to place personal survival over principled politics. If the Indo-US nuclear deal had boosted his image, 2G